

Politeness Scoring Annotation Guidelines

Overview

The goal is to rate each email conversation based on how well it employs politeness strategies as defined by Brown and Levinson's theory. This theory suggests that speakers use strategies (or "face-saving" devices) to mitigate face-threatening acts (FTAs) and to preserve both their own "face" and that of their interlocutors. In our context, annotators will look for indicators of both **positive politeness** (strategies that show friendliness, solidarity, and common ground) and **negative politeness** (strategies that reduce imposition and acknowledge the recipient's desire not to be imposed upon).

Annotation Granularity

Granularity:

Politeness scoring operates at the **email level**. Each email is treated as a discrete unit for assigning politeness scores.

Annotators should carefully review each email by reading both the initial email and its corresponding reply, if present. If there is no reply, they should read only the initial email, including the subject line and opening and closing greetings, and then consider the following factors:

Key Criteria to Evaluate

1. Directness vs. Indirectness

1. **Bald on Record**: Extremely direct and clear request without any attempts to minimize the imposition on the hearer. It's characterized by a direct and unambiguous way of saying things, without softening the request.
2. **Direct variants**: imperatives, statements about the addressee's obligations like "You must...", "You have to..."
3. **Direct start**; for example: **So**, can you retrieve it or not?
4. **Direct questions**: **What** is your native language?
5. **1st person plural**; for example: Could **we** find a less complex name . . .
6. **Indirect (btw)**; for example: **By the way**, where did you find...

Directness vs. Indirectness

Score 1 	Score 2 	Score 3 	Score 4 	Score 5 
• Bald on Record. • Direct variants. • Imperatives with zero mitigation. • Statements of obligation.	• Direct start. • Direct obligation phrased as a question or statement. • Straightforward questions about facts. • No prefatory softener. • Imperatives framed mildly but still no hedging ("Please do X." can sometimes be 2 if "please" is tacked on but does not genuinely soften).	• Direct requests or questions that embed minimal conversational framing. • No real hedges beyond "so" or "and." • No first-person plural, no "by the way,". • No layered mitigation.	• 1st person plural "we" or "us" to share responsibility • No overt "by the way," but the request is phrased as part of a joint decision. • No outright imperative; it reads as collaborating rather than ordering.	• Indirect (By the way), "I was wondering," or similar discourse marker. • No imperatives or forceful obligation statements. • Often phrased as a side comment or background question.

2. Positive Face Saving

1. **Negative lexicon**; for example: If you're going to **accuse** me . . .
2. **Positive lexicon**; for example: **Wow!** / This is a **great** way to deal. . .
3. **Greetings** (opening, closing); for example: **Hey**, I just tried to...
4. **Deference**; for example: **Nice work** so far on your rewrite.
5. **Gratitude**; for example: I really **appreciate** that you've done them.

Positive Face Saving

Score 1 	Score 2 	Score 3 	Score 4 	Score 5 
• Negative lexicon. • No greetings/closings. • No Deference, No Positive lexicon.	• Slightly Positive lexicon. • Greetings (opening or closing).	• Positive lexicon. • Basic Greetings. • Some signs of Deference.	• Full structure of Positive lexicon. • Greetings (opening and closing). • Deference.	• Positive lexicon. • Gratitude. • Greetings (opening and closing). • Deference and Gratitude are smoothly integrated.

3. Negative Face Saving

1. **The 2nd person starts**; for example: **You've** reverted yourself . . .
2. **Please start**; for example: **Please** do not remove warnings.
3. **The 2nd person**; for example: But what's the good source **you** have in mind?
4. **Please in the middle of a sentence**; for example: Could you **please** say more...

Negative Face Saving

Score 1 	Score 2 	Score 3 	Score 4 	Score 5 
• Second-person start. • No “please” anywhere (neither at the start nor mid-sentence). • The tone feels like a blunt statement or command addressed directly to the hearer.	• Second-person start or prominent “you”. • Exactly one “please” somewhere in the sentence, but not at the very beginning. • The “please” is tacked on and does not change the fact that the sentence feels addressed to “you” right away.	• Second-person used, but not necessarily as the very first word. • One “please” appears—often immediately before or after a verb. • No “Please” at the very beginning, but the “please” signals a genuine request. • The overall tone is neither harsh nor overly deferential; it sits in a neutral middle ground.	• The sentence starts with “Please”. • Second-person (“you”) may still appear, but it follows the Please start. • The tone is more respectful: the request is fronted by “Please” rather than “You.”	• The “please” comes with would/could.., • No blunt second-person start (either no “you” at the very first word, or “you” appears only after additional hedges). • In sentences, “please” may also appear (layering of courtesy markers). • The phrasing is explicitly deference-oriented—often combined with a softening phrase or mild hedging (“if you don’t mind,” “would you be so kind,” etc.).

Email Examples

Example Score 1 – Very Impolite

Email Body:

Subject: REPORT NOW

Send me the Q2 numbers immediately. Don't make excuses.

Directness vs. Indirectness (Score 1):

- Bald on Record: "Send me..." with no softening.
- Imperative with zero mitigation: "Send me the Q2 numbers immediately."

Positive Face Saving (Score 1):

- No greetings or closings.
- Negative lexicon: "Don't make excuses."

Negative Face Saving (Score 1):

- Second-person start ("Send me...").
- No "please."
- Blunt, commanding tone.

Example Score 2 – Moderately Impolite

Email Body:

Subject: Need Q2 Report Today

Hi John,

Please send me the Q2 numbers by the end of today. I need them for the meeting.

Thanks.

Directness vs. Indirectness (Score 2):

- Direct obligation phrased as a polite imperative: "Please send me the Q2 numbers..."

- No layered mitigation—“please” is tacked on but doesn’t genuinely soften.

Positive Face Saving (Score 2):

- Includes a greeting (“Hi John,”) and a closing (“Thanks.”).
- Slightly positive lexicon: “Thanks.”

Negative Face Sving (Score 2):

- Second-person presence (“send me,” “I need”).
- Exactly one “please,” not fronted at the very start of the sentence.
- Tone remains directive and time-sensitive, though softened minimally.

Example Score 3 – Neutral / Mixed Politeness

Email Body:

Subject: Q2 Numbers Request

Hi John,

Could you send over the Q2 numbers when you have a moment? I’m preparing for tomorrow’s meeting and want to include them.

Thanks in advance.

Directness vs. Indirectness (Score 3):

- Direct request with minimal conversational framing (“Could you send…”).
- No first-person plural; no “by the way.”
- No layered mitigation beyond “when you have a moment.”

Positive Face Saving (Score 3):

- Basic greeting (“Hi John,”).
- Basic closing (“Thanks in advance.”).
- Positive lexicon: “Thanks in advance” conveys mild appreciation.

Negative Face Saving (Score 3):

- Second-person used (“Could you send...”), but not as the first word.
- One “please” is implicit in “Could you,” rather than “Please send.”
- Tone sits in a neutral middle ground: respectful but not overly deferential.

Example Score 4 – Moderately Polite**Email Body:**

Subject: Request for Q2 Report

Hi John,

I hope you’re doing well. Would it be possible for us to receive the Q2 numbers by tomorrow morning? We appreciate your help with this.

Thank you for your attention.

Best regards,

[Your Name]

Directness vs. Indirectness (Score 4):

- Uses first-person plural (“us”) to share responsibility and soften: “for us to receive...”
- No overt “by the way.”
- The phrasing is collaborative rather than commanding: “Would it be possible...”

Positive Face Sving (Score 4):

- Full greeting (“Hi John,”) and closing (“Best regards,”).
- Positive lexicon: “I hope you’re doing well,” “We appreciate your help.”
- Deference: “Would it be possible for us to receive...”
- Gratitude integrated smoothly: “Thank you for your attention.”

Negative Face Saving (Score 4):

- The sentence starts with a hedging opener (“I hope you’re doing well.”), not a blunt second-person.
- Uses “would”/“possible” rather than a direct “you.”
- The tone is respectful and collaborative.

Example Score 5 – Very Polite

Email Body:

Subject: Gentle Request for Q2 Report

Good morning John,

I hope you and your family are doing well. If you don’t mind, would you be so kind as to send the Q2 numbers at your earliest convenience? It would greatly help us prepare for our upcoming review. We understand you have a busy schedule, so please feel free to let us know if you need more time.

Thank you very much for your assistance, and please let me know if there’s anything I can do to help in return.

Warm regards,

[Your Name]

Directness vs. Indirectness (Score 5):

- Highly indirect: “If you don’t mind, would you be so kind as to...”
- No forceful obligation or imperative.
- The entire request reads as a side comment, shifting weight to listener’s ease.

Positive Face Saving (Score 5):

- Complete greeting (“Good morning John,”) and closing (“Warm regards,”).
- Positive lexicon throughout: “I hope you and your family are doing well,” “would you be so kind,” “greatly help,” “thank you very much.”
- Deference and gratitude smoothly integrated.

Negative Face Saving (Score 5):

- No blunt second-person start—first part is “Good morning John, I hope you and your family are doing well.”
- In-sentence “please” appears: “please feel free to let us know.”
- Phrasing is explicitly deference-oriented and considerate: “If you don’t mind,” “would you be so kind,” “at your earliest convenience,” offering reciprocal help.

These emails are provided solely as examples to illustrate the scoring system; they may not appear in the actual dataset.

Annotation Process

1. **Read the entire email:** Include subject lines, greetings, or closings, body and its reply. Consider the email as a whole unit for scoring (not at the sentence or phrase level).
2. **Evaluate Using Key Criteria:** For each email, review and reflect on the following five criteria (see detailed explanations/examples above).
3. **Assign a Score:** Based on the criteria above, choose a score from **1 to 5**.